




rediscovered it during the Renaissance (15th and 16th centuries), but it took the French Revolution of 1789 to turn a whole people into the equal citizens needed to populate such a force.

The revolutionary regime's *levée en masse* of 1793 proposed conscription not as an arbitrary exercise of a ruler's power over its subjects but as an appeal to the duty of the citizens of a country to fight for their nation. The change in the status of the soldier that this implied was reflected, if imperfectly, in a change in how soldiers were treated, even in the armies that fought against revolutionary France. The regulations of the British Rifle Brigade, raised in 1800, state that an officer or NCO "shall give his orders in the language of moderation and of regard to the feelings of the men under his command" and that "duty should be done from cheerfulness and inclination, and not from mere command and the necessity of obeying". The men who fought in the American Civil War 60 years later initially elected their officers, and in many cases obeyed them only when they saw fit.

The mobilization of its citizens gave a modern state the potential to field armies numbered in millions. Western societies made a conscious effort to maintain or revive the warrior spirit in this age of mass warfare. School children were taught of the glory of dying in battle for the homeland. The warriors of the past were praised as heroes to be imitated. At the outbreak of the American Civil War (1861–1865), and later of World War I (1914–1918), many otherwise peaceable young men rushed forward to enlist, keen to test themselves in combat. But the supremely destructive battlefields of the 19th and 20th centuries on the whole failed to fulfil the assumed promise of heroic adventure. Patriotic propagandists seeking for warriors to glorify found them among the ace fighter pilots of the two world wars or elite soldiers such as the German stormtroopers. But the reality of modern conflict was more honestly represented in the erection of Tombs of the Unknown Warrior, and in mass military cemeteries that celebrated the anonymous courage and sacrifice of the common man. The soldier who fought at Gettysburg, the Somme, or on the D-day beaches of France, was typically a most unwarriorlike individual, his natural habitat an office, factory, or farm. Yet these civilians in uniform proved time and again impressive fighting men when forced into the cauldron of battle.



